**like it's a second nature**

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/62594356.

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|---|---|
| Rating: | Teen And Up Audiences |
| Archive Warning: | No Archive Warnings Apply |
| Category: | M/M |
| Fandom: | 崩坏：星穹铁道 \| Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game) |
| Relationships: | Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Mydei & Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail) |
| Characters: | Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Aglaea (Honkai: Star Rail) |
| Additional Tags: | Fluff, Fluff and Angst, Light Angst, Intimacy, Non-Sexual Intimacy, Idiots in Love, Possessive Phainon, Possessive Behavior, Jealous Phainon, Fluff and Humor, Mild Hurt/Comfort, Hair Braiding, Bathing/Washing, Blood and Injury, Banter, Bickering, Getting Together, Mutual Pining, 5+1 Things, No Beta we Die like me rn |
| Language: | English |
| Series: | Part 1 of bound by the stars |
| Stats: | Published: 2025-01-29 Words: 9,304 Chapters: 1/1 |

# like it's a second nature

by kj_crwn

Summary

Mydei almost snorts at the way Phainon's jaw clenches, invisible to an untrained eye.

"Perhaps another time?" Phainon laughs easily, placing himself at Mydei's side and smoothly extracting him from the woman's grip. He places his hand on Mydei's nape in a friendly manner, tugging lightly on his hair. "We have some important business to attend to right now. Sorry to take Mydei here away from you, I'm *sure* he was having the time of his life."

or; 5 times Phainon is a jealous and possessive idiot over Mydei, and 1 time Mydei returns the favor

Translation into Russian (Русский) available: here

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

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“I will perfect it, Lord Mydei,” the boy vows, sweat running down his forehead as he struggles to keep breathing evenly.

Despite his clear exhaustion, he is grins at Mydei with conviction. That’s the only reason Mydei doesn’t call the practice short. Aias is the last one still standing, the most promising of the Kremnoan warriors Mydei took upon himself the task of training.

“Less talking and more doing,” he says, clicking his tongue.

Aias salutes him halfheartedly and falls back into the stance. It’s far from perfect; his legs are too close together, and his hand is bent at the wrong angle. His brows furrow as he concentrates and throws the spear. It strikes the target, not too far from the bullseye.

It’s a better result than it should be by any means.

Aias scowls, muttering a curse under his breath. Evidently, he is also dissatisfied with it.

Mydei sighs and steps forward to him. He hears the door opening behind him, but pays it no mind. People constantly mill around the practice grounds, coming in to observe how the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos runs the drills. There were five civilians and three Okheman soldiers already sitting by the wall when Mydei first arrived

Aias picks up another spear, assuming the stance once more. Mydei grasps his throwing arm to adjust it just slightly and kicks his legs further apart, while nudging the boy’s shoulder to signal he should bend his torso just a little bit forward. Aias lets Mydei position him without a word of protest, eyes tracking Mydei’s movements and committing the changes to memory.

“Bloodthirst and fierce ambition are valuable driving forces,” Mydei says, altering the angle of the non-dominant hand to aim more precisely, “I, of all people, would know. But you must calm yourself. Breathe. Throw in a straight line and aim slightly higher than the target’s center.”

He takes a step back and looks Aias up and down. The boy maintains the stance perfectly, waiting for a command like a warrior on the battlefield.

“Release,” Mydei orders dispassionately, expecting the same result only with better execution.

Aias throws the spear a split second after Mydei’s command. He hits the bullseye perfectly.

It’s quiet for a moment, before Aias bursts out in a delighted laugh, some bystanders applauding. The warriors who had already given up on the training for the day groan, witnessing their peer surpass them already. Aias grins at everyone before turning to Mydei, eyes visibly sparkling with hero worship.

Mydei huffs with exasperation and allows for a small smile as he walks closer to him again. “Good job,” he praises, ruffling the boy’s red hair.

The gift of clairvoyance isn't required to know that Aias will have a bright future, rising through the ranks at an astonishing pace. Mydei has no doubt that Aias would have been one of the most competent and fiercest royal guards in his retinue, were he born in the time of Castrum Kremnos' glory.

Mydei lowers his hand, about to tell Aias to resume the practice and check whether he can already mimic the stance after just one try.

“It didn't pass my mind you’d be taking a personal approach,” Phainon’s grating voice stops him from somewhere behind the two of them. “I don’t recall any of my instructors giving hands-on directions.”

Neither of them flinches at the sudden interruption. Aias does spin around a moment later, though, brimming with excitement. He opens his mouth, presumably to ask Phainon for a spar as he tends to pester everyone about, but snaps it shut when Mydei sends him a stern look.

“Perhaps if they did, you would have bested me by now,” Mydei remarks drily, not bothering to face him properly. Phainon does it for him, stepping around so they stand across each other with Aias in between them.

“We’ve tied plenty of times before,” Phainon says with an eye roll. “I can win against you at any moment. I graciously haven’t done so before as to not ruin your reputation.”

“Did you come here just to pick a fight with me?” Mydei asks, feeling his eyebrow twitch. “Don’t you have better things to do, Deliverer?”

Aias snickers quietly and goes to pick up a few more spears from the rack.

Phainon smiles sharply, gaze narrowing. “Why, are you scared you will actually lose? What would your little *student* here think of it, I wonder.”

Mydei itches to pull a page from the teachings of Ulixes and immediately throw Phainon to the floor with a nasty trick of sorts.

Aias jogs back to them, carefully placing the spears on the ground and leaving just one in his hands. He props it up against the ground, leaning on it lazily while his eyes jump between Phainon and Mydei. He finds great entertainment in whatever is transpiring, evidently.

“Never in my life have I been afraid to lose,” Mydei says. “Now, are you done wasting my time? As you have pointed out, I have a student to take care of.”

Phainon’s smile freezes in place at the dismissal, eyes wandering to Aias, sizing him up as if he is wondering what’s so special about the boy. Aias only grins widely under Phainon’s harsh scrutiny, whereas anyone else would be falling over their feet to appease the Golden Boy of Amphoreus. Truthfully, there isn’t that much to it. The boy is exhausted enough by

now that they should've called it a day an hour or two ago. Mydei simply desires to go against whatever it is Phainon is playing at.

"I don't plan on leaving anytime soon. Please, go enjoy yourself, Lord Mydei," Aias waves him away like Mydei is here solely for him. The audacity, truly. He then turns his attention to the other man. "And no hard feelings, Lord Phainon," he says cheekily.

"See, you're free now," Phainon ignores the last remark and glances at Mydei instead. "Now I feel obligated to fill up the empty space in your schedule. What a perfect opportunity to spar, would you look at that?"

Mydei raises his hand to rub the bridge of his nose. Insufferable. Insatiable as well, from the looks of it.

"Come on, we will keep it between the two of us if you lose, I promise."

Mydei grits his teeth, breathing out harshly. "Who am I to decline your desperate wish if you desire to *also* be taught how to fight properly?"

He pushes past Phainon, their shoulders colliding, and heads for the exit. They can't fight here, not if they don't want the whole room to collapse. No, they have a dedicated space where outsiders aren't allowed, and destruction won't pose any problems.

"Great!" Phainon reacts brightly. He catches up to Mydei easily, keeping up with his pace. He takes one look back at the training room and swiftly changes the subject. "Your student is strange."

Mydei shrugs, unconcerned. "Good kid. He will make an excellent fighter one day."

"I've never heard you praise anyone openly," Phainon comments conversationally. "Is he really that impressive?"

"I give my praise where it's due," is all Mydei offers as an answer.

He doesn't get another teasing remark back like he expected. No quip about him growing soft for the novices or anything of the sort. Instead, Phainon grows quieter and more subdued, as if stuck in his own thoughts, all the way to their practice field. Mydei doesn't inquire what that could be about. Even if he wanted to get a closer look at Phainon's mind, it's not like he would ever willingly mention his insecurities to Mydei.

But a little thought gnaws at the back of his head while they warm up, followed by a destructive fight. It persists until they're finished, another tie decided by the appointed four-hour mark running out rather than either of them being unable to continue.

Mydei knows Phainon carries a burden that weighs on him like the world upon Kephale's shoulders. The Perfect Hero, the Boy Savior. Deliverer. People might worship Aglaea for her beauty and wisdom, but it's Phainon they turn to with their problems, trusting him to help every soul in need of saving. But Phainon is running from his past, heading towards

retribution, silently questioning his own choices and path. Willingly or not, Mydei can read him like a book after so many years spent in each other's company.

Sitting on a piece of a broken pillar, he finishes up tying the cloth torn from his sleeve around the cut on his bare forearm, gold immediately staining the dark fabric. No matter, he only needs to slow the bleeding enough to kickstart the healing factor. Using his teeth to hold one end of the fabric to tighten it up properly, Mydei glances at Phainon as he staggers over to collapse on the ground next to him. Phainon is a little worse for wear, looking as if he's still continuing the fight, except this time against the severe dizziness. Otherwise, he is surprisingly unharmed. Mydei did throw him into a wall with what could be a bit too much force, after all. The man stares up at the sky, his eyes somewhat unfocused and a frown marring his face. There is a shallow cut on his cheek, the armpiece gone, and the cape barely holding on.

Mydei sighs, looking somewhere above Phainon's sprawled figure.

"Phainon," he calls to snap him back to attention. "I will not be repeating myself, so listen closely."

"Huh?"

Maybe he is concussed and won't remember much of this after he has healed. Mydei can only hope. He swipes his tongue against his teeth, trying to choose the words carefully.

"There isn't much I can say about your skill because you are near perfection in every regard. You should be aware of it by now. My student may be a prodigy, but he will be lucky if he ends up with a fraction of your skills."

Mydei grew up in an environment where praise was reserved for those who struggled in order to motivate them to move forward despite their failures. Even then, it was rare—most frequently sprinkled in the midst of rough words and dark scenarios, insults and provocation. If you excel at everything, you get a nod at best and move on to the next weapon to master.

Mydei is *attempting* to be a better instructor for Aias. Krateros was an excellent teacher. An invaluable advisor as well as an incredible mentor. But he was also a stern man, hardened by war in ways that made him unable to give reassurance where it was needed. Aias reminds Mydei of his youth. An unbreakable will and need to advance at lightning speed. But Mydei also remembers his mother watching on from the sidelines as he fought in the tournaments, how warm her scant few words of praise felt, and how much more it meant than the laurels placed on his head with every win.

"I've been training to fight almost since the moment I took my first steps," Mydei continues thoughtfully. "It's the essence of my life. And yet, I find myself questioning whether I've ever felt as much… thrill and anticipation in the battles I have fought as I do during our spars. You are capable of going blow for blow with Mydeimos the Undying, Phainon. It's an achievement that very few individuals could claim in all the years."

When he glances down, he finds Phainon propped up on his elbows and staring at him in shock, eyes having entirely regained clarity. Fuck. Not so concussed, then.

It’s too late to back out, so he might as well stick with it.

Mydei smiles, sharp and unflinching. “I’m looking forward to the day you finally manage to claim one of my deaths.” It’s as much of an offer as it is an admission. He isn’t certain Phainon will grasp just what exactly it means, but it doesn’t matter.

That makes Phainon snap out of it, pushing himself up to sit with his knees bent in front of him. “I will *never* go that far,” he says seriously, *fiercely*.

Mydei raises an eyebrow in a silent question. And why not?

“Immortal or not, your life is too precious.” Phainon declares with such conviction, and Mydei swears he sees his eyes flash. “I won’t let you die if we are side by side on a battlefield, just as I will claim my win against you fairly, with you *yielding* beneath my blade.”

Mydei suddenly feels hot under Phainon’s intense gaze, the words searing deep into his brain. It feels oppressive. He could get lost in the feeling it’s evoking in him, unwilling to let go once he has it in his grasp.

*Ah.*

So, that’s what it’s going to be?

Mydei swallows, trying to keep his composure. “I will gladly witness you fulfill that promise, Deliverer.”

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Mydei isn’t necessarily enjoying the situation he is currently stuck in.

He believes that it’s fairly obvious to everyone that he prefers solitude over meaningless chatter and pointless noise. He’s been told he isn’t the most approachable of people numerous times ever since he was a child. Too fast to anger, too ambitious, too scary, too intense. Simply too much, and yet never enough of softness and easy laughter. It wasn’t as much of an issue in Castrum Kremnos, where the qualities he possesses were valued over everything else. Add to it the golden blood thrumming through his veins, liters upon liters of it spilled across the battlegrounds, more than any other soldier's. The curse he is bearing and a body that might not age, but he bears some marks of time, nonetheless.

He finds he doesn’t care that the people of Okhema don’t find his personality *appealing*. They don’t have to.

And yet, there are always some people who buzz around him like flies, as if they’re begging for attention. Perhaps it’s the title of a Chrysos Heir that acts like a magnet.

“Lord Mydeimos, you are truly extraordinary,” one of the ladies chuckles, a delicate hand covering her mouth. She is blushing for some reason, despite the water’s temperature being perfectly regulated.

The young man next to her nods enthusiastically, smiling coyly. “Your skills are unmatched. It’s a pity you never come down to have fun with the rest of us, Lord Mydei.”

Mydei hums noncommittally. He debates just telling them he finds their company insufficient. Maybe that would discourage them enough to allow him to pass. But Okhemans don’t appreciate the straightforward honesty in the same way Kremnoans do.

“I appreciate the invitation,” Mydei says slowly, not looking at any of them and instead gazing at the Hero’s Bath in the distance. At this rate, it might be empty by the time he manages to make his way over. Small mercies. “But I’m afraid my schedule wouldn’t allow for that.”

“Surely you could spare an hour or two for us?” Another woman almost purrs at him, trailing her hand along his arm. Mydei doesn’t flinch—that reflex has been beaten out of him at a very early age—but he has to consciously keep himself still to not push her away. He doesn’t appreciate the uninvited touch of any kind. “We won’t tell if you won’t,” she whispers, adjusting her robes with the other hand.

As if anyone ever had to tell Aglaea what goes on in any building she is in.

Alright, he reached the daily quota of attempting to *behave* and be *kind*, as Tribbie loves to berate him about. He is about to tell them off and make sure people won’t be getting any ideas to disturb him anytime soon again—the gossip mill never disappoints in making him seem like a monster. At least it garners him some peace for a little while—but then, he notices a familiar figure heading their way.

Mydei stays put, watching as the man quickly treads through the water, the decorative red petals drifting to the sides with the force of his stride.

“My, isn’t Mydei popular today?” His irritating voice eventually rings behind the trio, full of humor.

“Lord Phainon!” The girl gasps, splaying her hand more firmly on Mydei’s biceps, as if in shock. “I can’t believe we’re this lucky. Now that you’re here, would you like to join all of us?”

Mydei almost snorts at the way Phainon’s jaw clenches, invisible to an untrained eye.

“Perhaps another time?” Phainon laughs easily, placing himself at Mydei’s side and smoothly extracting him from the woman’s grip. He places his hand on Mydei’s nape in a friendly manner, tugging lightly on his hair. "We have some important business to attend to right now. Sorry to take Mydei here away from you, I’m *sure* he was having the time of his life.”

Mydei clears his throat to cover up the beginning of laughter threatening to spill from his throat without explicit permission. He can’t help it, not with the way Phainon says it so

earnestly when Mydei is fully aware he doesn't mean a single word.

All three of them nod, like it's perfectly understandable, and finally back off. Phainon catches Mydei's wrist and drags him away with one last winning grin to the strangers. Mydei lets himself be led away for all of ten seconds before he tears his hand away, scowling at Phainon in what he hopes will come across as annoyance.

"You're welcome, by the way," Phainon comments idly, not even looking his way.

"Whyever would I be?" Mydei hums, debating with himself whether he should just throw him into the water and go by himself. It would be pointless; Phainon is unfortunately capable of catching up. "I had it handled."

Phainon lets out a genuine laugh at that, sending an amused look at Mydei. "They were five minutes away from eating you alive."

As if. Mydei scoffs, pushing at Phainon's shoulder to make him stumble. "I would like to witness them trying."

"Yeah, you might be an esteemed warrior," Phainon says, trying to trip Mydei up but only clicking his tongue when Mydei instead kicks his shin away, "But a master of social cues you are not."

"You're one to talk, Boy Savior," Mydei replies as they step onto the floating platform. The guard standing by it gives them a short nod before returning to her duty. "You would break your back trying to appease every single person asking a favor of you."

Phainon doesn't seem to have a response to that, glaring at him instead. But then, the platform moves up, and when Phainon looks down at the people below them, his gaze catches on Mydei's attire.

"And would it kill you to dress a little more modestly?" Phainon asks, pinching the bridge of his nose with one hand and gesturing with the other to the cloth Mydei wrapped around his hips before heading out to the baths.

Mydei raises an eyebrow at him. It reaches around the middle of his thighs, which is perfectly modest in his opinion. "Didn't think you would be such a prude," he says, crossing his arms.

Phainon's eyes follow the motion, forcefully devoid of any emotion. He lets out an annoyed sigh, snapping his eyes to meet Mydei's. Mydei resists the urge to smirk. "It's called being decent."

"I'm starting to think dictionaries in Castrum Kremnos differed from whatever you were using growing up," Mydei remarks as he steps off the platform. "Perhaps someone should finally teach you the proper meaning of some words."

Aglaea is already seated to the right, waving in their direction as she sips from the goblet. Mydei and Phainon make their way over, their bare shoulders brushing.

"Why, are you offering to be my teacher?"

“Wouldn’t you like that,” Mydei says, slipping around the round table to take a seat at Aglaea’s side.

Defying Mydei’s expectations, Phainon goes in right behind him, closing off the way to easily leave. It’s not like Mydei cannot just go over the seat, but that would look too much like fleeing.

Mydei gives him a flat look. Phainon smiles back pleasantly.

“You’re lively as ever, boys,” Aglaea says into her goblet, her amusement ringing loud and clear despite the mild tone.

“It would be boring otherwise, wouldn’t it?” Phainon grins, leaning down to pick some grapes from the table. His bathing robes slip down a little, revealing the ridiculously muscled chest and stomach. Mydei hastily looks away.

“Of course,” Aglaea nods along. Her unfocused gaze settles between the two of them. “You bring out the best in each other.”

Mydei and Phainon both turn to face her, blinking in confusion.

“I would ask whether your eyesight is functioning alright,” Mydei says drily, picking up the pomegranate juice, “but unfortunately we know the answer to that.”

Phainon chokes on a grape.

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“Lord Phainon hates me,” Aias says, biting into the apple at his side as Mydei hands over the balance coins to Demetria.

Phainon was right, he is a little strange. Mydei doesn’t remember the last time someone had so much disregard for the titles. Sure, Aias uses them but does not treat them with nearly as much respect as everyone else. He also doesn’t shy away from going wherever he pleases, strutting up to Mydei’s side at any given moment as if he has a standing personal invitation.

Not that Mydei minds, it’s refreshing to have someone around who isn’t afraid of offending him with the slightest of things.

“Nonsense,” he says, slipping the pomegranates into the pouch attached to his belt.

Demetria thanks him profusely as she always does when they get ready to leave, pushing another apple free of charge into the boy's hand. Mydei knows Aias will be back to help her carry some of the heavier supplies later as a form of repayment.

“Yeah, well. I was messing with Kelok’s fake shields and Lord Phainon was walking back from Kephale Plaza,” Aias recounts, staring at his apple. Mydei makes a mental note to tell Aglaea the fraud merchants are back at it again. He is starting to doubt anything will ever deter them from continuing their scam. “I called for him, and he was smiling and all when he came over, but I got the impression he was one wrong word away from running his greatsword right through me. I wouldn’t be opposed to it, you know. Seeing a weapon like that from up close? Once in a lifetime experience for me. Though I would prefer to see it in a fight, not when I’m being killed because he thinks I’m your new favorite.”

“I don’t have favorites,” Mydei protests as they move past Kyros, nodding to the man in a greeting.

“Sure,” Aias snorts, taking another bite from the apple. Mydei doesn’t bother berating him to swallow before speaking, aware by now it’s pointless. “But can you let him know I’m just nineteen and not a grandpa like the two of you? I’d greatly appreciate it. Maybe he will finally realize I’m not trying to do what he thinks I am. Which is just disgusting.” Aias wrinkles his nose in exaggeration, followed by an amused grin. “No offense, Lord Mydei. Just, not exactly my sort of thing.”

Mydei is about to retort and ask what in the world he is even prattling on about, but Aias stops in his tracks with a loud groan, like his day has just been utterly ruined. Mydei follows his line of sight and notices a person with characteristic almost-white hair and a bright blue cape standing at the Treasures of Ages.

“Seriously? I’m not up for this today,” Aias mutters, looking around desperately. Mydei waits patiently until the boy’s gaze settles on Chartonus Smithy, and his entire face lightens up. “Oh, but *that* is my sort of thing. Sorry, Lord Mydei, I will leave early today.”

Aias breaks into a jog, running past Phainon without a glance back.

“Hey, Thanasis! Fancy seeing you here,” is the last thing Mydei hears from him. A taller boy, perhaps two years older than Aias, turns to greet him, long dark hair sweeping past his shoulders.

Mydei shakes his head, walking up to Phainon instead. He might as well, since he’s already here.

“—doesn’t mean it makes it right. He deserves better.” Mydei catches the tail end of Phainon’s rant, watching as he anxiously runs his hand through his hair and tugs on the strands a little.

Mydei has no idea what he could possibly be so worked up about. He comes to a stop behind him, noting the way his shoulders are tensed. He doesn’t say a word, expecting Phainon to notice sooner or later, like he always does. Theodoros takes one look at him and opens his mouth to presumably greet him, but Phainon is evidently on a roll today.

“I suppose it’s better than the last time when the Councilman’s granddaughter attempted to bribe him into marriage. I can’t imagine a more disrespectful act. He is the most honorable man I know, and she tries to *buy* him?”

He sees Phainon shake his head in what's probably distaste. Theodoros changes his mind about addressing Mydei quickly, letting Phainon go on.

"At least this time the suitor is someone more capable. I— I imagine he might be attracted to one of the Okhema's most prominent warriors," Phainon stutters over his words a little, losing some of the annoyance and instead appearing resigned. "The gift they commissioned also seems… Impressive."

Mydei should probably make himself known by now. In fact, he is about to reach out for Phainon, touch his shoulder and—

"It's just, do they even know *anything* about Mydei?"

Mydei stills at hearing his own name fall from Phainon's lips. Now that he thinks about it, he vaguely recalls receiving one or two marriage proposals since arriving in Okhema. He declined them without paying them as much as a thought. He didn't even know one of them could have been the granddaughter of a member of the Council of Elders. His eyes snap to Theodoros who looks like he would rather be anywhere else than here.

"I'm sure he doesn't even know they *exist*, and Mydei is bound to find someone he will like and would want to actually marry, and perhaps it will be this one, only Kephale knows." Phainon sounds like he's running out of steam, his shoulders hunching down with every word. "But why do they get to express their affection, genuine or not, when—"

Phainon cuts himself off sharply. He takes a deep breath in, lets it out, and stands straight again. Mydei would bet everything that his expression is forcefully softened out, a perfect mask in place. If it wasn't for the very few who care to look past it. Mydei feels a sense of mortification at hearing Phainon openly pondering his love life, out in the street. Is he even aware of what he sounds like?

"I must apologize, Theodoros." Phainon lets out a small laugh, an attempt to release the tension. "I'm afraid seeing your new exceptional dolium and hearing the rumors again fed on some of my other frustrations, resulting in… this. I shouldn't have let it all out on you."

"No worries, Lord Phainon," Theodoros reassures him, sounding remarkably sincere. Perhaps it's not the first time Phainon has taken to rambling to the owner. Then, he turns and finally greets Mydei awkwardly, "It's a pleasure to see you at my store, Lord Mydei."

Phainon outright flinches at the words, whirling around to see that yes, Mydei is indeed right behind him. His face flushes at an astonishing rate. Mydei stares right into his eyes angrily. Phainon's face goes through three different stages before he ultimately settles on the approach he's going to take.

"I suddenly remembered I've got important matters to attend to. Please, excuse me." Fully confident in his decision, he attempts to go past Mydei.

Oh, fuck no.

Mydei grabs him by the shoulder and pushes him back to where he was standing. Phainon easily resigns himself to his fate, already looking sheepish.

“I’m not marrying *anyone*, you fool,” Mydei eventually speaks up, a little strangled. He feels himself flushing. Great. For good measure, he hits Phainon over the head, careful of the gauntlet still covering his hand.

Phainon hisses in pain and rubs the spot with a weak glare. “I knew you wouldn’t,” he quickly backtracks, his hand lowering to scratch the back of his neck. “I suppose I’m just frustrated by their audacity.”

*Why do you care?* Mydei wants to ask. If only there was a possibility of getting a straight answer back.

Theodoros clears his throat, and Mydei is reminded that these are private matters. They shouldn’t be burdening this poor man with their mess any longer.

“You scared my pupil away,” he changes the subject, glancing at the smithy and finding both of the boys gone.

“What— I haven’t even seen him today,” Phainon says with a frown, confused.

Mydei pinches the bridge of his nose. Aias was also right, Phainon is being something of an asshole to him on purpose. As much of an asshole as Phainon is even capable of being to anyone that isn’t Mydei.

“And yet he ran away from me the moment he saw you. You owe me an evening of company, Phainon.”

It’s a weak excuse to get away, but he doesn’t care anymore. It’s less embarrassing than Phainon’s prior rambling, and that’s enough for him. Before Phainon can get another word in, Mydei nods in apology to Theodoros and grabs Phainon’s forearm to drag him away.

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“I’m so sorry, Lord Mydeimos,” the woman apologizes for what must be a twentieth time, gazing up at the sky like she wishes Kephale would come down and save her from the mortification.

Mydei doesn’t wince when her daughter tugs viciously on his hair, attempting to fight it into some semblance of a braid. “It’s alright,” he reassures her mildly.

He had been napping on one of the larger lily pads in the Garden of Life, tired after a successful expedition. He hoped people would let him rest peacefully in the warm sunlight and fresh air, but perhaps that was too much to ask for. Although that might be on him for choosing such a public place, despite the astonishingly early hour when the majority of

Okhema should have been asleep. There are only a scant few people milling around the streets at the Entry Hour, usually.

Unfortunately, he awoke about half an hour later to small hands digging around in his hair, and a little chimera yawning up at him from its resting place on his stomach. He must have been drained more than he initially assumed if the small thing managed to climb up on top of him without rousing him. Mydei initially lifted his head up to see who the other offending party was, just to find a young girl blinking down at him with a toothy grin. In the very next moment, the mother ran in, almost tearing up on the spot when she noticed her daughter messing with Mydei. Surely the rumors circulating about him don't paint him cruel enough that people assume he would hurt a child?

And so, he finds himself propped up on one elbow while the girl twists the strands of his hair this and that way and lets the icy-blue chimera gnaw on his fingers, while the woman nervously watches on.

"Lord Phainon," the woman suddenly calls in a greeting, now appearing as if she's about to faint. Perhaps she's just bad at dealing with people? Mydei can relate, although in his case, it's more about the annoyance at them rather than anxiety.

"Hello," Phainon says cheerfully, taking it as an invitation it is not, and walking onto the lily pad.

He sits cross-legged right in front of Mydei, sending him a strange look. Much to Mydei's amusement, the chimera stops its task of trying to consume his finger and turns to roar fiercely at Phainon. He picks it up by its middle, ignoring the chimera's wiggling, and sticks his tongue out at it childishly. Then, he returns it to Mydei's side, where it huffs at him angrily.

Cute.

He means the chimera, of course.

"Not in my wildest dreams have I thought I would witness you being so… domestic out in the open," Phainon says, looking to the girl and back at Mydei, then to the mother.

"Oh, but you've dreamed of my domesticity in more private settings?" Mydei cannot help but make the teasing comment, smirking when Phainon's eyes widen. He splutters something out in protest, but Mydei simply talks over him with a snort. "Do I truly seem incapable of softer acts?"

"No, of course not. You're one of the kindest men I know." A small smile finds its place on Phainon's face as he says it.

Mydei stares at him in confusion. Not a statement he expected.

"It's just that I—" Phainon trails off, clearing his throat and deciding to abandon the subject. He tilts his head instead. "Don't you hate when your hair is touched?"

Mydei raises an eyebrow at him. He doesn't recall ever mentioning it to him, or anyone, actually. Unless it was during one of the feasts, where he possibly got drunk enough to forget. Unlikely, but within the realm of possibility.

The girl yanks on his hair violently, and Mydei breathes through the sharp stinging. There is a chance he will be leaving without some chunks of hair. "I do."

The mother makes a strangled sort of noise, covering her face with her hands. "Sweet Kephale, I'm *sorry."*

Phainon chuckles and places a comforting hand on her shoulder before shuffling closer to the girl. "Would you like me to teach you the way girls back in my homeland used to tie their hair?" He asks the girl softly somewhere above Mydei's head, and Mydei can very easily imagine the beaming smile he shows her.

It's an understatement to say that the girl is very enthusiastic about Phainon's offer. Phainon guides her hands away and tries to coax her into keeping a gentle grip on Mydei's hair. It's slow going, but eventually, she learns to be delicate enough that Mydei can barely feel the touch. After a few minutes, he is asked to turn onto his stomach entirely so that they can have easier access to both sides of his head. He complies easily, letting out a tired sigh as he rests his forehead on his forearms. Phainon's fingers put the slightest pressure on his scalp when he weaves the strands around expertly, quietly relaying instructions to the kid working alongside him.

Mydei shifts a little and blinks sluggishly at the chimera that wormed its way to lie down beside his face, yawning once and then licking his nose before closing its eyes to sleep, basking in his warmth. Without even realizing it, Mydei follows in its lead, eyes growing heavier until darkness welcomes him in a peaceful embrace.

He doesn't know how long he dreamlessly sleeps for. Some time later, he is brought back to consciousness with a feeling of someone still delicately running their fingers through his hair. Mydei breathes in and out, finally noticing his head is now propped up on someone else's lap.

It's one thing to not realize a harmless child or a chimera came up to him until one of them actually disturbed him. It's another to be repositioned without flinching back to awareness with a blade at the ready.

Mydei blinks his eyes open and is welcomed to the land of the living by the sight of very familiar boots and a coat.

"Phainon?" He asks the obvious, voice rough. He is still sitting cross-legged, Mydei's head resting sideways on his thigh.

"Oh—" Phainon immediately stops whatever he is doing and pulls his hands away. Mydei frowns into the fabric of his pants. "Sorry. The braid was coming a bit loose in Eirini's section. I was trying to fix it."

Who? Oh, right, must be the child. Mydei never bothered asking for the name. There is a more pressing issue, though.

“Did I tell you to stop?” He mutters, turning his head to glare up at the man.

“Uh?” Is Phainon’s very intelligent reply, eyes clearly confused.

*“Continue.”* Frustrated, Mydei clicks his tongue and lazily reaches up to grab one of Phainon’s hands and pushes it back against his head, closing his eyes again. And only then does the action catch up to his brain. Fuck. “I can’t walk around with my hair half undone,” he provides a flimsy excuse, hoping the embarrassment doesn’t show in his voice. Or that the heat he feels rising on his cheeks doesn’t transform into a blush.

“R—right,” Phainon sounds a little strangled, but he does hesitantly resume the task at hand.

Mydei turns his head back to stare at Phainon’s coat instead. The chimera walks around from behind Phainon, strutting up to Mydei’s head, and stretches up, leaning its front legs against Phainon’s shin.

Phainon being *Phainon*, doesn’t let the awkward silence fester for long.

“It wasn’t very happy with me when I moved you,” Phainon says, mockingly hurt. “I was shocked you didn’t wake up from its mighty roars.”

Mydei reaches out to pet in between its ears, as a thank you to his fierce protector. The light-blue, almost-white fur is soft beneath his fingertips. The bright blue eyes close in satisfaction. Mydei idly wonders whether he might have some sort of affinity for the blue color.

“By the way, the mom wanted me to tell you she is very grateful to you for indulging her daughter,” Phainon starts chattering mindlessly as he works.

Mydei has no idea whether he’s actually doing anything new to his hair, or if he’s simply redoing what’s already perfect just to have something to do with his hands. He lets himself drown in the words, pretending he isn’t listening as intently as he is. Apparently, the woman warmed up to Phainon and told him about their complicated family situation. It’s unsurprising that people adore Phainon and open up to him like flowers yearning for the sun’s warmth. The girl got bored halfway through but still wanted to watch Phainon work. After they departed, Phainon didn’t want to disturb Mydei, so he didn’t wake him up. Mydei is treated to a small lecture about overworking himself, immortal or not, in not as many words. He calls Phainon out on the hypocrisy of the statement, and so they start arguing quietly as life goes on in the Garden of Life.

For once, no one else bothers them.

Approximately two hours later, they separate without much fanfare. Except for the way Phainon appears a little flustered, but seemingly unable to look away from Mydei. He smiles more, less intent on goading Mydei.

It’s only near the end of the day that Mydei catches the view in the mirror, his breath hitching. The look suits him, yes. But he is stuck wondering whether in Aedes Elysiae braids might hold a fraction of what they meant in Kremnos. He strongly doubts it, but the braids

are intricate enough to make him believe they might be more important than something every villager girl wore on a daily basis.

He squints at the mirror, searching for the part he remembers the little girl starting on before he fell asleep, Phainon selecting larger sections of hair for her to work on. He finds the one braid she completed replaced by three much smaller ones, clearly redone by Phainon in a different style. Something glints in the light when he turns his head to inspect the other side. He curses as he tries to angle his head in a way that would allow him to catch a glimpse of the object. Eventually, he succeeds and sees a golden pin, an exact replica of the ones hanging all over Phainon's daily garments.

Did he— did he break some pieces apart to weave them into Mydei's hair?

He reaches behind with his hand, gently moving his fingers to check whether there's more. Sure enough, two more pins that seem to be the same shape are placed at the back of his head, right next to where the braids turn into a short ponytail. Mydei doesn't look into the mirror for the rest of the day, irritated at the way his entire body feels flushed whenever he recalls his image looking back at him.

Allowing an innocent child to pointlessly play around with his hair for a brief moment doesn't hold any meaning or importance. Whereas having it done so expertly in such an intricate way, with personal mementos left in by the man dear to him?

It takes Mydei three days to convince himself to undo the braids, feeling like he is losing a piece of something important while he does it. It's ridiculous. Phainon couldn't even have *meant* it.

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"You could have lost your leg," Phainon almost hisses at him from where he is sitting and diligently observing the healer closing the wound on Mydei's back. All of his armor is gone, as is most of his outer attire. What's left are the dark pants and loose shirt, its sleeves rolled up above his elbows.

Mydei sends him a flat look. He still doesn't have any feeling from the knee down in said leg. He raises his thigh to performatively glance at the stitches running all around his shin. When they finally got to the camp, it was only holding on by some of the muscles only, skin slashed, and bones broken. Phainon almost carried him in, but Mydei doesn't ponder on that too long, at risk of feeling humiliated.

"What an astute observation, have you considered changing your profession to a doctor?" Mydei asks with an eye roll, dropping the thigh down.

He attempts to wiggle his toes. No luck.

If he hadn't already almost lost his arm in the past, he would have been starting to panic by now about whether his curse even affects severed limbs.

"It's not *funny,"* Phainon raises his voice, not falling for the bait for once. "Stop trying to make jokes."

The silence that follows is tense.

Mydei is unsure whether he's ever seen Phainon that stressed. As strange as it is, it's also curious. He feels the urge to poke him more, to see the ugly rearing its head.

Yet he keeps quiet, seeing as it's genuine distress marring Phainon's features.

The healer doesn't comment on their behavior, doing her job as thoroughly and quickly as she can. Once she's done, she puts her tools away and rinses her hands. Phainon and Mydei wait patiently, not exchanging another word. She returns to Mydei's side to relay the instructions on how to care for the wounds, her stern gaze wordlessly telling him that he better follow them or there will be consequences. Mydei might have skipped over a few steps and ended up with serious infections once or twice before, relying on his enhanced healing too much. It's not a big problem for him; he can bear through the pain until it goes away on its own. Apparently, that's unacceptable. Wisely, he nods along despite barely listening, not mentioning that he simply intends to go and sleep it off.

As she exits, two aides come in past her, undoubtedly having waited by the door for her to be done. They giggle as they walk in, eyes trailing over Phainon but settling on Mydei with heat.

Mydei's skin crawls.

"We've heard you've been seriously injured in the battle, Lord Mydei," the taller one says with a grin.

"We would like to offer help with anything you might require while recovering," her friend says, slightly shyer.

The first girl gazes at Mydei's chest, covered in bruises, blood, and all kinds of dirt. She covers up a wince rather expertly. "We could start with a bath."

Mydei is about to decline as he always does. He knows it's common for soldiers to use the aides, sometimes out of necessity, other times purely because the offer has been made. He never accepted, and he doesn't intend to.

However, that seems to be the last straw for Phainon's temper. "Absolutely *not,"* he snaps at them, gripping the armrest so tightly it makes a cracking sound.

The two girls startle, looking at Phainon with wide eyes, perplexed. Phainon isn't ever harsh with the civilians, always with bright smiles and gentle words. Mydei idly wonders whether anyone has ever witnessed Phainon lose it aside from him. Well, and the two girls before him, except they got a *mild* version.

Mydei takes pity on them, snapping his fingers at Phainon to get him to stop glaring at the poor girls. “We will be fine,” he says in a clear dismissal. “Thank you.”

“Yes— yes of course,” one of them stutters out.

“Lord Mydeimos. Lord Phainon.”

They both bow to them before quickly scurrying back out of the door and shutting it firmly behind them.

Phainon looks at him, suddenly conflicted. Mydei feels the beginning of a migraine forming at the back of his head that’s entirely unrelated to his injuries.

“They are right, actually,” Phainon says quietly, almost pained to admit that. “I don’t trust you to clean yourself before sneaking out, let alone be mindful enough to avoid getting water into your wounds.”

“I’m not a child,” Mydei reminds him, irritated. He can take care of himself without a babysitter.

“Obviously,” Phainon snorts humorlessly, eyes staring almost vacantly at the entrance to the adjacent bathroom.

Mydei looks toward the bathroom as well, then back at Phainon. He doesn’t even let himself consider it.

“No.”

*“Mydei,”* Phainon cuts in, voice desperate and lips thin, his eyes nearly begging. “I need this. Please.”

Curse him, and curse Mydei, and curse that fucking leg he nearly lost.

“Fine,” Mydei says curtly.

Never in his life would he have thought himself *weak*, and yet he folds under that pleading gaze like a wet sheet of paper. May Titans strike him.

“You’re *not* carrying me,” Mydei adds quickly, knowing what Phainon’s next goal would be.

Phainon looks like he wants to argue, but decides not to push his luck. He helps Mydei stand up on one leg and doesn’t watch when he pulls the robes loose, letting them fall onto the ground. Mydei isn’t embarrassed about his nude form, more out of necessity rather than vanity. He has been bathing among soldiers ever since he can remember. There is no such thing as privacy when you’re in the army, leader of it or not.

Phainon’s hand wraps around Mydei’s waist to support him, not very happy when Mydei throws his arm around his shoulders to gain some sort of balance, and a drop of blood leaks out of the big cut on his back. Without a word, they shuffle towards the bathroom. Much to Mydei’s displeasure, it still feels one step away from Phainon carrying him. At least it

appears more dignified than a bridal carry. He assists Mydei in getting into the bath that's been filled with warm water beforehand by the healer, making a great effort to keep Mydei's hurt leg out of it. It's an awkward position, but neither of them cares. Phainon drags over a basin filled with water to rinse in it most of the dirt that will gather on the cloth. He starts by running water over Mydei's chest, hands moving quickly and methodically, never lingering. He moves to carefully clean his back around the stitched wound with a cloth, rinsing it and repeating the process until it stops staining the water with gold.

He then moves to Mydei's injured leg. He gets stuck in his head when he takes a closer look at the stitches but shakes himself out of it, forcing himself into wiping his bloodied shin clean.

Mydei still cannot feel a damn thing.

Phainon's hands are trembling.

Mydei leans forward and maintains his face as neutral as possible, not allowing the wince at the pain when the stitches on his back are pulled with the motion to show through. Phainon's gaze tells him that he's aware it hurts, nonetheless. He grabs Phainon's hand that's closer to him and keeps a tight hold on it.

"Phainon," he says, keeping his voice quiet and gentle. "I am alright."

"I lost sight of you for twenty minutes and didn't— You were overrun," Phainon says through clenched teeth, angry at himself. "If I didn't come back in that very moment, you would have—"

"I would still be alright," Mydei reminds him, squeezing his hand to keep him tethered.

Hypotheticals are meaningless. Especially in this situation, when death doesn't desire to claim Mydei, spitting him out as soon as he succumbs to it.

"I said I would watch your back," Phainon insists, his own grip on Mydei tightening almost to a painful degree. "What good am I for when I can't even keep the one I— the person closest to me safe?"

He will talk himself into a panic attack at this rate.

Mydei pulls him closer and slightly over the bathtub's edge, using his other hand to guide Phainon's head to the crook of his neck. He buries his fingers in the white hair and massages his scalp, hoping it's a soothing gesture.

Eventually, Phainon's breathing steadies enough to continue.

But he only calms down entirely when he is washing Mydei's hair, touch so soft it's barely noticeable. Mydei will blame the blood loss for the delirious wish to have his hair pulled tighter by him. To distract himself, he tries moving his foot again, surprised to find that there's finally some reaction. He raises his hand to touch Phainon's cheek to get his attention,

not wanting to disturb the peaceful silence. Phainon tilts his head into Mydei's palm in a question. Mydei points at his leg and wiggles his toes at Phainon, smirking up at him.

*See? Already recovering.*

Phainon chuckles, *finally* coming back to himself.

His hands still work on Mydei's hair, fingers occasionally wiping around his eyes to keep the water from getting in. So tender and focused to make Mydei feel better, to make the process less painful.

Mydei splashes some water on him to avoid doing something reckless.

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Aglaea stops talking when she realizes Mydei's attention is otherwise occupied. It's rude of him, he knows, but he cannot help it. Suddenly, the plot of the novel they've both read—Aglaea in the special edition for the blind, as her Sight cannot distinguish words written on paper—doesn't appear so appealing. She doesn't berate him, instead raking her unfocused gaze over the Plaza until she spots what he's staring at.

"Ah," she hums softly. "Our esteemed guests. And Phainon."

Mydei recognizes them as strong allies. He truly does. He also appreciates all their help.

It doesn't change the way his blood boils when he watches the way the grey-haired one latches onto Phainon's arm, gesturing this and that way until his finger pokes at the dark choker wrapped around Phainon's neck.

"I suppose we will continue our discussion at a later date," she continues, her amusement increasing by the minute. She taps his hand to get his attention and smiles at him with warmth when he turns back to her. "It's going to be today, isn't it? I'm happy for you. It has been in the works for years."

Mydei scoffs halfheartedly but taps her hand back in silent gratitude regardless. She knows everything, of course she is aware of what's going on between him and Phainon. But he doesn't think anything in particular will happen today. Maybe later, when the two men depart for whatever it is they do, he will get Phainon to spar with him to release some of the anger he feels right now. Not exactly fair to Phainon himself, but he is one-half of the problem Mydei is facing right now.

The next time he looks over, Phainon is busy taking the choker off. Mydei narrows his eyes. What's even the—

Caelus slowly reaches out to Phainon's mark. Was he an animal, Phainon's tail would be wagging enthusiastically, happy to satisfy someone's burning curiosity.

Mydei is walking to them at a brisk pace before he even realizes it.

“May you be blessed by Mnestia, Mydeimos,” Aglaea calls after him with a chuckle.

Mydei doesn’t have to say anything back for her to know what exactly he thinks of that statement. Still, deep down, he appreciates the sentiment.

The other man—Dan Heng, he remembers, the more reasonable one—notices him first. He glances quickly at his friend. Debating whether he should tug Caelus back, Mydei suspects, but eventually decides to let the situation play out. Once he is close enough, Mydei deftly slips his hand around Phainon’s neck, covering the mark before the guy’s fingers can make contact. Phainon barely even reacts, merely stumbling one step back and into Mydei’s chest when Mydei pulls him along.

“If you would refrain from putting your hands on what’s mine, that would be greatly appreciated, *strangers.”* He doesn’t snarl at them, because that’s unbecoming. But his voice is laced with as much of a threat as he can put into it, eyes narrowed dangerously.

“There is nothing to worry about,” Dan Heng immediately assures him, finally yanking his companion back to his side. “We aren’t interested in the slightest.”

Caelus makes a noise of disagreement. “Well—"

“We are *not,”* Dan Heng repeats, louder. He glares at his friend and then sends Mydei and Phainon an apologetic look. “In fact, we are leaving. Thank you for indulging Caelus, Phainon.”

Not waiting for a response, he forcefully drags Caelus away by his hand, ignoring the yells of *“I told you!”* screamed right into his ear. Mydei wonders where that patience comes from.

“Um. Are we going to address this at all?” Phainon speaks up hesitantly, still pressed against Mydei.

Mydei’s mind goes blank. He—

He didn’t intend to escalate that far. But they do say love is blind, so perhaps his vision slightly narrowed in the heat of the moment.

“That depends,” he says, pulling his hand back and stepping away. He is glad he left the gauntlets behind today. “Is it finally clear enough for you? Or should we just move past it like the other times?”

Phainon grins sheepishly, not even attempting to play dumb. “I didn’t think you’d notice.”

“I’m not blind,” Mydei sighs. Is this really the man who has him wrapped around his little finger? “Nor am I stupid. Of course, I noticed. I simply wondered why you wouldn’t commit to it.”

“I wasn’t sure you would be into this,” Phainon admits, his smile turning slightly self-deprecating. “Not just me, but the whole love thing.”

If only he knew. Mydei sincerely hopes Algaea never sees fit to have a thorough discussion with Phainon about Mydei's tastes.

"I am," Mydei confirms, exasperated. Phainon will be the end of him. "Both of those things, especially when you're concerned. Now, will you stop doubting yourself?"

"I might require some more reassurance," Phainon hums, the insecurity fading away for now. He smiles coyly, stepping back into Mydei's space.

There we go.

"I shall do my best to provide, then," Mydei says with a smirk.

He grabs a hold of the belt strap running across Phainon's chest and yanks him closer, clashing their lips together. Phainon laughs against his lips, his hands finding their way into Mydei's hair, tilting his head to deepen the kiss.

Mydei's own hands settle on Phainon's hips and hold on possessively. He doesn't intend to ever let this man go.

End Notes

yeah so it's 3 am and i desperately needed to get this out of my system, so here it is. i did not manage to edit it in its entirety so excuse any typos and etc, i will most probably get back to it once i wake up

anyway, i'm weak for them. i have a plan for another shorter (unrelated) fic so i added this into series just in case
also in mythology, deimos is a son of ares, but also of aphrodite. mydei is a secret romantic and you will not convince me otherwise. would love to imagine that he talks romance with aglaea every now and then

haaaaah, i don't have any braincells left to add more notes. title of the fic (and series, maybe the description but i doubt it) might change once i regain the consciousness and the brain power along with it
[edit: i woke up, and tired me put on mature rating by habit aahhhh it's changed to T now
i also want to add that i sorta wanted the possessiveness go beyond that physical aspect it usually is? like, yes, phainon hates when other ppl touch mydei. but he is also jealous to see him domestic with others when he can't be in a sense that he wants to be and feels like it's unfair that others can confess to mydei when he cannot, etc, so there you have it lmao
also. guys. don't edit at 3 am. mistakes have been made and by now mostly fixed, dear lord]

i'm @kj_crwn on twt
i always make playlists for what i'm writing, so here is the phaidei playlist i've been listening to when writing this, more or less. i'll be adding more once i get to writing the second fic, ig?
hope you enjoyed!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!